Banking Exam Pattern Guide 2026

BankPrep AI | Banking Exam Preparation Study Material
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How to use this guide

This guide gives the 2026 exam pattern for SBI PO, SBI Clerk, IBPS PO, IBPS Clerk (now called Customer Service Associate, CSA), IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I (RRB PO), IBPS RRB Office Assistant (RRB Clerk) and RBI Assistant. Each exam section repeats the exam name so that any single section can be read on its own.

Patterns were compiled on 9 October 2026 from the 2026 notifications as summarised by multiple education sources. Banks and IBPS change patterns between cycles (SBI PO and IBPS PO both changed in 2026). Always confirm on the official notification at sbi.bank.in/careers, ibps.in or rbi.org.in before an exam.

Common rule for all objective sections in these exams: Negative marking: one-fourth (0.25) of the marks assigned to a question is deducted for each wrong objective answer; there is no deduction for unanswered questions.

SBI PO (Probationary Officer) - Overview 2026

SBI PO 2026 has three phases: Phase I Preliminary Examination, Phase II Main Examination (objective plus descriptive), and Phase III (Psychometric Test, Group Exercise and Interview). The 2026 cycle (Advertisement CRPD/PO/2026-27/09) had 1,500 vacancies. Prelims was held on 1 and 2 August 2026 and Mains on 12 September 2026.

Age limit is 21 to 30 years and any graduate can apply. SBI PO exams are bilingual (English and Hindi) except the English Language test and the descriptive paper.

SBI PO - Prelims Pattern

SBI PO Prelims is an online objective test of 100 questions for 100 marks in 60 minutes, with a separate 20 minutes per section.

SBI PO Prelims English Language: 40 questions, 40 marks, 20 minutes. Quantitative Aptitude: 30 questions, 30 marks, 20 minutes. Reasoning Ability: 30 questions, 30 marks, 20 minutes.

SBI PO Prelims is qualifying only. Its marks are not added to the final merit. There is no sectional cut-off in Prelims; candidates are shortlisted for Mains on aggregate Prelims marks, category-wise.

SBI PO - Mains Pattern

SBI PO Mains 2026 has an objective test of 170 questions for 200 marks in 3 hours, followed by a descriptive test of 30 marks in 30 minutes. Total Mains is 230 marks in 3 hours 30 minutes. Important 2026 change: the descriptive test was reduced from 50 marks to 30 marks, so Mains total fell from 250 to 230.

SBI PO Mains Reasoning and Computer Aptitude: 40 questions, 60 marks, 50 minutes. Data Analysis and Interpretation: 30 questions, 60 marks, 45 minutes. General, Economy and Banking Awareness: 60 questions, 60 marks, 45 minutes. English Language: 40 questions, 20 marks, 40 minutes.

SBI PO Mains descriptive test: 3 tasks typed online in English in 30 minutes for 30 marks - email writing, situation analysis, and report writing or precis writing (choice within each). There is no

negative marking in the descriptive test.

SBI PO Mains has sectional qualifying marks decided by the bank, so each Mains section must be cleared individually.

SBI PO - Phase III and Final Selection

SBI PO Phase III has a Psychometric Test (no marks), a Group Exercise of 20 marks and an Interview of 30 marks, totalling 50 marks. About three times the number of vacancies per category are shortlisted from the Mains merit list.

SBI PO final merit: Mains marks (objective plus descriptive) are scaled to 75 and Phase III marks are scaled to 25, for a total of 100. Prelims marks are not counted.

SBI Clerk (Junior Associate) - Overview 2026

SBI Clerk (Junior Associate, Customer Support and Sales) 2026 has three stages: online Preliminary Examination, online Main Examination, and a Local Language Proficiency Test (LLPT) for candidates who have not studied the state's local language in Class 10 or 12. The 2026 notification was for 9,766 vacancies. There is no interview.

SBI Clerk final merit is prepared state-wise and category-wise from Mains marks only. Prelims marks are not added to final merit.

SBI Clerk - Prelims Pattern

SBI Clerk Prelims is an online objective test of 100 questions for 100 marks in 60 minutes, with 20 minutes per section.

SBI Clerk Prelims English Language: 30 questions, 30 marks, 20 minutes. Numerical Ability: 35 questions, 35 marks, 20 minutes. Reasoning Ability: 35 questions, 35 marks, 20 minutes.

SBI Clerk Prelims is qualifying in nature; there is no sectional cut-off. Candidates are shortlisted for Mains in descending order of aggregate marks (about 10 times the vacancies).

SBI Clerk - Mains Pattern

SBI Clerk Mains has 190 questions for 200 marks in 2 hours 40 minutes (160 minutes) with separate sectional timing.

SBI Clerk Mains General and Financial Awareness: 50 questions, 50 marks, 35 minutes. General English: 40 questions, 40 marks, 35 minutes. Quantitative Aptitude: 50 questions, 50 marks, 45 minutes. Reasoning Ability and Computer Aptitude: 50 questions, 60 marks, 45 minutes.

In SBI Clerk Mains, the Reasoning and Computer Aptitude section has 60 marks for 50 questions, so some questions carry more than one mark. The penalty for a wrong answer is one-fourth of the marks assigned to that question. No minimum qualifying marks are prescribed for individual sections.

SBI Clerk LLPT is qualifying only and its marks are not counted in merit.

IBPS PO (CRP PO/MT-XVI) - Overview 2026

IBPS PO 2026 (CRP PO/MT-XVI) recruits Probationary Officers and Management Trainees for participating public sector banks. It has three stages: Preliminary Examination, Main Examination (objective plus descriptive) and Interview. IBPS PO Prelims was held on 22 and 23 August 2026 and Mains on 4 October 2026.

IBPS revised the IBPS PO pattern for 2026: both the Prelims marks distribution and the Mains structure changed. Study material from earlier years may show the old pattern.

IBPS PO - Prelims Pattern

IBPS PO Prelims is an online test of 100 questions for 100 marks in 60 minutes, with 20 minutes per section; candidates cannot switch between sections.

IBPS PO Prelims 2026 English Language: 30 questions, 30 marks, 20 minutes. Quantitative Aptitude: 35 questions, 30 marks, 20 minutes. Reasoning Ability: 35 questions, 40 marks, 20 minutes. Marks per question differ by section in the revised pattern: Reasoning carries 40 marks and Quantitative Aptitude carries 30 marks.

IBPS PO Prelims is qualifying only and marks are not included in the final merit list. Candidates must clear the cut-offs set by IBPS to be shortlisted for Mains.

IBPS PO - Mains Pattern

IBPS PO Mains 2026 has an objective test of 170 questions for 200 marks in 160 minutes, with separate sectional timing, followed by a descriptive test of 25 marks in 30 minutes. Total Mains is 225 marks in 190 minutes.

IBPS PO Mains Reasoning: 40 questions, 60 marks. General, Economy, Banking, Digital and Financial Awareness: 50 questions, 60 marks. English Language: 40 questions, 20 marks. Data Analysis and Interpretation: 40 questions, 60 marks. One source reports the Reasoning section at 45 minutes; check the notification for the other sectional timings. Sources differ on whether the Reasoning section name still includes Computer Aptitude; the revised notification is reported to have dropped it as a separate test.

IBPS PO Mains descriptive test: 2 questions (essay and comprehension), 25 marks, 30 minutes, typed in English. IBPS has stated the descriptive paper may be evaluated using an automated scoring system.

IBPS PO - Interview

IBPS PO Interview carries 100 marks. Candidates who clear the Mains cut-offs are called for the interview. Prelims marks are not counted in final merit.

IBPS Clerk / CSA (CRP CSA-XVI) - Overview 2026

From the 2026 cycle (CRP CSA-XVI), the IBPS Clerk post is officially named Customer Service Associate (CSA). The notification was released on 1 August 2026. There are two online exams, Preliminary and Main, with no interview. A Local Language Proficiency Test applies where required.

IBPS Clerk Prelims is scheduled for 10 and 11 October 2026 and Mains is tentatively scheduled for 27 December 2026; confirm dates on ibps.in. Final merit is based on Mains marks only.

IBPS Clerk - Prelims Pattern

IBPS Clerk Prelims is an online test of 100 questions for 100 marks in 60 minutes, with a fixed 20 minutes per section and no carry-over of unused time. The Prelims pattern is unchanged from earlier cycles.

IBPS Clerk Prelims English Language: 30 questions, 30 marks, 20 minutes. Numerical Ability: 35 questions, 35 marks, 20 minutes. Reasoning Ability: 35 questions, 35 marks, 20 minutes.

IBPS Clerk Prelims marks are used only for shortlisting and are not added to final merit.

IBPS Clerk - Mains Pattern

IBPS Clerk Mains was revised for 2026 (CRP CSA-XVI): it now has 160 questions for 200 marks in 125 minutes, with separate sectional timing and no switching between sections.

IBPS Clerk Mains Reasoning Ability: 40 questions, 60 marks, 35 minutes. General English: 40 questions, 40 marks, 35 minutes. Quantitative Aptitude: 40 questions, 50 marks, 35 minutes. General and Financial Awareness: 40 questions, 50 marks, 20 minutes.

The main change in 2026 is in Quantitative Aptitude, which went up to 40 questions for the same 50 marks. The official Mains table names the first section Reasoning Ability and does not list Computer Aptitude as a separate test, though some sources still use the older name.

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I (RRB PO) - Overview 2026

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I (the RRB PO) is conducted for Regional Rural Banks. The stages are Preliminary Examination, Main Examination and Interview. According to the IBPS 2026-27 calendar, the Officer Scale-I Prelims is scheduled for 21 and 22 November 2026.

Officer Scale-II and Officer Scale-III do not take Prelims; they appear directly for a single-level examination followed by an interview.

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I - Prelims Pattern

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I Prelims is an online test of 80 questions for 80 marks in 45 minutes with two sections: Reasoning and Quantitative Aptitude (40 questions each). Some sources report separate sectional timing and others a composite 45 minutes; check the notification.

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I Prelims marks are used for shortlisting only and are not part of final merit. Both sectional and overall cut-offs apply to Officer Scale-I.

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I - Mains and Interview

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I Mains is an online test of 200 questions for 200 marks in 120 minutes with five sections: Reasoning, Quantitative Aptitude, General Awareness, English or Hindi Language, and Computer Knowledge.

IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I has an Interview carrying 100 marks after the Mains. Unlike the Office Assistant post, Scale-I includes an interview in the selection process.

IBPS RRB Office Assistant (RRB Clerk) - Overview 2026

IBPS RRB Office Assistant (Multipurpose) is the RRB clerk-level post. The stages are Preliminary Examination, Main Examination and a Local Language Proficiency Test where applicable. There is no interview. Final selection is based on Mains marks only.

According to the IBPS 2026-27 calendar, the Office Assistant Prelims is scheduled for 6, 12 and 13 December 2026.

IBPS RRB Office Assistant - Prelims and Mains Pattern

IBPS RRB Office Assistant Prelims is an online test of 80 questions for 80 marks in 45 minutes with two sections: Reasoning (40 questions) and Numerical Ability (40 questions). Prelims marks are used for shortlisting only.

IBPS RRB Office Assistant Mains is an online test of 200 questions for 200 marks in 120 minutes with five sections of 40 questions each: Reasoning (50 marks), Numerical Ability (50 marks), General Awareness (40 marks), English or Hindi Language (40 marks), and Computer Knowledge (20 marks). One source reports sectional timings of 30 minutes for Reasoning, 15 for Computer Knowledge, 15 for General Awareness and 30 for English or Hindi; check the notification.

RBI Assistant - Overview 2026

RBI Assistant is the only clerical-level post recruited directly by the Reserve Bank of India. The 2026 notification was released on 16 February 2026, and the Prelims was held in April 2026. There are three stages: Preliminary Examination, Main Examination and a Language Proficiency Test (LPT). There is no interview.

RBI Assistant final merit is prepared only from Mains marks. The LPT is qualifying: candidates who fail it are disqualified irrespective of their Prelims or Mains scores. The LPT checks reading, writing and speaking in the regional language of the concerned RBI office.

RBI Assistant - Prelims Pattern

RBI Assistant Prelims is an online objective test of 100 questions for 100 marks in 60 minutes with sectional timing of 20 minutes per section.

RBI Assistant Prelims English Language: 30 questions, 30 marks. Numerical Ability: 35 questions, 35 marks. Reasoning Ability: 35 questions, 35 marks. Prelims is qualifying and its marks are not counted in final merit.

RBI Assistant - Mains Pattern

RBI Assistant Mains is an online objective test of 200 questions for 200 marks in 135 minutes with sectional timing. It has five sections of 40 questions each: English Language, Numerical Ability (Quantitative Aptitude), Reasoning Ability, General Awareness, and Computer Knowledge.

RBI General Awareness covers banking, economy and RBI topics, so the Banking Awareness study material is directly relevant to the RBI Assistant Mains.

Quick Comparison

Exams with an interview: SBI PO (Group Exercise 20 marks plus Interview 30 marks), IBPS PO (Interview 100 marks), IBPS RRB Officer Scale-I (Interview 100 marks).

Exams with no interview: SBI Clerk, IBPS Clerk (CSA), IBPS RRB Office Assistant, RBI Assistant. These select on Mains marks only, with a language test where applicable.

Prelims is qualifying only (not counted in final merit) in all seven exams. Descriptive tests exist only in the PO-level Mains: SBI PO (30 marks) and IBPS PO (25 marks).

Prelims total duration: 60 minutes for SBI PO, SBI Clerk, IBPS PO, IBPS Clerk and RBI Assistant; 45 minutes (80 marks) for both IBPS RRB posts.

Mains total marks: SBI PO 230 (200 objective plus 30 descriptive), IBPS PO 225 (200 plus 25), SBI Clerk 200, IBPS Clerk 200, IBPS RRB Scale-I 200, IBPS RRB Office Assistant 200, RBI Assistant 200.

Sources and Update Notice

Compiled on 9 October 2026 from 2026 exam pattern summaries by education sources that cite the official notifications, with cross-checking between sources. Where sources disagreed, the difference is noted above. Not yet covered: IBPS SO, RBI Grade B, NABARD, SIDBI, IBPS RRB Officer Scale-II and Scale-III details. Always verify on the official notification.